Why Is Your Water Bill Going Up?

A plain-English look at PWD's proposed 2027 water rate increase

WESTBROOK CURRENTS

Prepared 2026-10-26 from Portland Water District's own public filings, Maine law, and state records.
This is a research summary, not legal or financial advice.

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1. What PWD Is Asking For

Portland Water District (PWD) wants to raise water rates starting January 1, 2027. For a typical home, PWD says this adds about **$3.12 a month** to the water bill. That number checks out — it matches PWD's own rate tables almost exactly.

Important: this is a **water-only** increase. It does not touch your sewer charge, which your town (not PWD) sets separately.

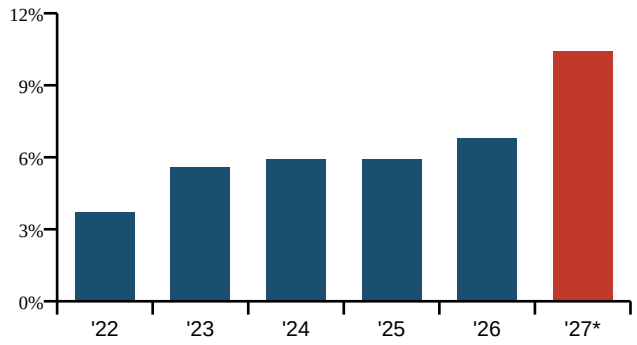
2. What the Percentage Really Means

The $3.12 comes from a **10.4% rate increase for homes** (11.2% counting businesses and others). That's close to **double** PWD's usual yearly increase over the last five years (about 5.6% a year on average).

3. Where the Money Actually Goes

- New wastewater treatment plant in North Windham ($42 million) — first loan payments start in 2027
- Replacing old water pipes across the district ($19 million)
- Fixing water and wastewater treatment plants and pump stations ($25 million)
- New digital water meters at every home ($11 million) — already started at Gerry's house in June 2026
- 8 new employees, mostly to support these projects ($1.9 million)
- PWD says rates will likely keep rising in future years too — not just in 2027

Six-Year History: Residential Water Rate Increases



■ Actual increase, 2022–2026 ■ Proposed for 2027 (not yet approved)

Dollar impact per year: 2022: +$0.81/mo • 2023: +$1.28 • 2024: +$1.52 • 2025: +$1.49 • 2026: +$1.92 • **2027 (proposed): +$3.12**

Did they find hidden damage? No sign of that in PWD's own materials. The reasons given are the usual ones for a big round of building and repairs: a major new treatment plant coming online, genuinely old pipes, and a planned meter upgrade — not an emergency.

Has Maine's Public Advocate weighed in? Not yet, and it's too early to expect it — PWD's trustees don't vote until Nov 23, 2026, and PWD doesn't file with the Public Advocate until after that.

VERDICT: Is This Fair?

Honest number, real reasons. The $3.12/month figure is accurate, and the reasons behind it are specific and traceable to real projects — not vague excuses. Nothing found here points to waste or a hidden emergency.

But the size of the jump is real, and worth a question. Almost double PWD's usual yearly increase, and PWD itself says more increases are coming after 2027. A simple, fair question to ask at the hearing: ask PWD for its multi-year rate forecast, not just 2027 — that shows whether this is a one-time catch-up or the new normal.

Sources: Portland Water District, "Water Rate Adjustment" and 2027 Proposed Comprehensive Budget Report (General Manager's letter), pwd.org, accessed 2026-10-26 • PWD current (eff. 1/1/2026) and proposed (eff. 1/1/2027) water tariffs, pwd.org/rates/ • PWD rate-adjustment history, 2022–2026, pwd.org news archive • Maine Revised Statutes, Title 35-A, Chapter 61 (§6104, §6104-A, §6104-B), legislature.maine.gov • Maine Office of the Public Advocate, maine.gov/meopa • Maine PUC Case Management System, mpuc-cms.maine.gov, checked 2026-10-26 • Gerry's own PWD billing history, 2022–2026 (52 bills), used to independently check PWD's $3.12 figure.